

ZOKARIO EDITIONS

The Paper Fox

*A bedtime tale for small listeners who are not
quite sure about the dark*

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CONTENTS

I The Fox on Page Forty

II Ink Still Wet

III The Margin Forest

IV A Bookmark for a Tail

V The Library at the Edge of Sleep

VI The Unfinished Sentence

VII Back Between the Covers

The Fox on Page Forty

Mira was brave about almost everything. She was brave about spiders, brave about thunder, brave about the deep end of the swimming pool. But when the lamp clicked off at night, her bravery folded itself up very small and hid somewhere near her toes. The dark, she was certain, was not empty. It rustled. It breathed. It rearranged the furniture when nobody was looking. So every evening she asked for the door left open, and the hallway light left on, and one more glass of water she did not really want.

In the corner of her room lived her grandmother's oldest book, a heavy thing with a cracked spine and pages the colour of weak tea. Mira was allowed to touch it, gently, on Sundays. But that night, while the hallway light hummed, she did something she had never done before. She slipped page forty free of its stitching, the page where a fox ran forever through printed grass, and folded it, corner to corner, crease by crease, the way Grandmother had once taught her, until a small paper fox sat in her palm with its ears up, listening.

At midnight, which is when all proper magic checks its watch, the paper fox stretched. It shook out its creases the way other animals shake out their fur. It hopped from the shelf to the blanket, walked up the hill of Mira's knees, and looked at her with eyes made of two small

printed letters. "You have been telling stories about my house," it said, in a voice like pages turning. "You say the dark is full of monsters. The dark is only a room, little folder. A room whose lamps you haven't met yet. Come and be introduced."

Mira meant to say no. She had a whole speech about it, kept somewhere near her toes with her bravery. But the fox took her sleeve in its paper teeth, gently, the way you hold something you have decided to keep. And the floor felt suddenly like the first page of something. Here, little listener, the free preview curls up and closes its eyes. In the full tale, Mira meets the lamp that lives in the wardrobe, the one that sleeps under the bed, and the oldest light of all. She learns why the dark keeps them, and why it kept her grandmother's fox.



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